

PAY BEARER Congress workers protesting the 'Adani-Modi nexus' in Delhi, Feb. 6

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

For BJP's ideological fountainhead Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and many of its affiliates, Adani has been a poster boy of the self-made, desi entrepreneur who made it big on the global circuit. The RSS-linked *Organiser* magazine sees the Hindenburg report and subsequent reactions by some global institutions as an attack on the Indian economy and part of a series of events that have "eventually benefitted China". It cited how not only Adani, but other groups such as the Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries and Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta Resources have had to undergo such attacks. 'These instances only prove that assaults on the Indian economy have now become very easy in an open and interconnected world. This is part of the fifth-generation warfare wherein hostile powers use various oblique tactics to target the Indian economy,' said one of its reports. It also pinned the blame on an 'Indian lobby which includes the country's famous propaganda websites associated with Leftist ideology'.

RSS affiliate Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM) has offered no direct defence of the Adani Group, but questioned the intent of Hindenburg Research. "What is their interest? In the US, there have been several instances where the courts have taken previous such reports by Hindenburg with a pinch of salt," says SJM convenor Ashwani Mahajan. In fact, most BJP leaders insist the report is part of a global conspiracy against Modi and India which, in their eyes, also includes the recent BBC documentary on the 2002 Gujarat riots that took place when he was the state's chief minister. "If that was a political attack, Hindenburg is targeted at India's economic resurgence," says a BJP minister.

ADANI'S FALL, IF IT HAPPENS, MAY IMPACT THE PM'S IMAGE, ESPECIALLY IF THE RBI AND SEBI ARE FOUND TO HAVE BEEN LAX IN MONITORING THE INVESTMENTS OF THE GROUP

Meanwhile, pro-BJP social media handles have openly come out in support of Adani. Social media platforms have been flooded with memes questioning the Hindenburg report. #IndiaStandsWithAdani has been among the top-trending hashtags on Twitter. Even some celebrities have joined this narrative, including godman Sadhguru and former cricketer Virender Sehwag. "The hitjob on India's markets looks like a well-planned conspiracy," tweeted Sehwag.

While the BJP may be successful in managing public perceptions, Adani's fall, if it happens, may impact the prime minister's image. Especially so if the RBI and market watchdog SEBI were found to be lax in monitoring Adani's investments and irregularities surface.

If the big-ticket infra projects sanctioned by the government to the Adani Group come to a halt, it will be a challenge for the prime minister to convince the nation about his government's intent in reposing faith in the business group. With just a year left to the next general election, any such mishap will put Modi on the back foot while giving the Opposition some much-required ammunition. "The allegations in the Rafale scam did not impact the common voters. Nobody could understand the scope of the scam. But in the case of the Adani scam, if the company goes bust, it will impact millions of Indians. Modi will have no escape route then," says a Congress Rajya Sabha MP. That may be taking things a tad too far, but there's no doubt that all parties concerned in the controversy will not come out looking too rosy. ■